

IN PROFILE

Harriet Smithson

Harriet Smithson (1800–1854) was an Irish actress noted for her beauty and her interpretation of Shakespearean roles. She began her career, aged just 14, at the Theatre Royal, Dublin. By 1818, she had moved to England, making her London debut at Drury Lane. She performed in comedies and tragedies, receiving good, though not outstanding, reviews. Smithson arrived in Paris in 1827. Once again, she acted in a variety of plays, but it was her performance as Ophelia in *Hamlet* that was really memorable. Berlioz saw the production and was spellbound, despite the fact that his English was limited.



PORTRAIT OF IRISH ACTRESS HARRIET SMITHSON, c. 1829

Obsessive love

In addition to opera, Berlioz also enjoyed drama, developing a great fondness for Shakespeare's plays. In September 1827, he visited the Odéon, where he witnessed productions of *Hamlet* and *Romeo and Juliet* by an English theatrical company. Berlioz was transfixed, falling desperately in love with the leading lady, Harriet Smithson (see box).